

W5YI

America's Oldest Ham Radio Newsletter

REPORT

Up to the minute news from the world of amateur radio, personal computing and emerging electronics. While no guarantee is made, information is from sources we believe to be reliable.

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Army MARS: "Not Operationally Ready"
New Blue Lazer Technology for DVDs
Group Sues Fax.com for \$2.2 Trillion
Dell to Market "White Box" Clone PCs
Pocket-Sized Computer Keyboard
"Black Box" Aimed at Teen Age Drivers
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FCC Commissioner Near Confirmation
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Next Space Mission to Include Teen Idol
Ham Radio Call Signs to September 1st
Amateur Radio Enforcement News
RSGB in Ham Experiment at 5 MHz

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INSPECTOR GENERAL AUDIT: ARMY MARS IS NOT "OPERATIONALLY READY"

"Army MARS provides communications support for federal agencies in responding to emergency situations on an international, national, and local basis as an addition to normal military communications." Mission: Army Military Affiliate Radio System

The Military Affiliate Radio System (or MARS as it is known) is a U.S. Department of Defense sponsored program, established as a separately managed and operated program by the Army, Navy, and Air Force.

MARS got its start in 1925 when an Army Signal Corps Captain decided to enlist the talents of volunteer Amateur Radio operators to train soldiers in the then new technology of radio. The Army Amateur Radio System (AARS) continued as a Signal Corp extra-curricular activity until World War II when all amateur radio operation was suspended. There were approximately 60,000 FCC licensed Amateurs at the time and some 5600 of those Amateurs were members of the AARS.

After the war, the AARS was reactivated and two years later became the Military Amateur Radio System when the Air Force was created as a separate service. It was later renamed to the Military Affiliate Radio System (MARS) in 1948. In early 1963, Army MARS and Air Force MARS was joined by the Navy-Marine Corps MARS. Each of the three MARS Chiefs is responsible for the day-to-day management and operation of their respective programs.

Army MARS Headquarters is located in southern Arizona at Fort Huachuca near the Mexican border. It is the largest of the three programs supposedly overseeing approximately 5,000 members. Air

Force MARS, located at Scott AFB, Illinois, and Navy-Marine Corps MARS (which also includes the U.S. Coast Guard), located in Washington, D.C. each have an affiliate volunteer population of approximately 2,000 members.

The mission of MARS

According to the *Department of Defense*, the mission of U.S. Army Military Affiliate Radio System is "...to provide emergency communications on a local, national, or international basis as an alternative communications capability." Operating on military frequencies, the program relies on both civilian licensed amateur radio operators and military MARS members to provide communications support in times of crisis.

To become an MARS member, a volunteer must be 18 years of age, be an FCC-licensed radioamateur and have a radio station capable of operating on HF or VHF MARS military spectrum.

The Army MARS website located at: <www.asc.army.mil/mars> says their mission is to "...provide auxiliary communications for military, civil, and/or disaster officials during periods of emergency."

Their home page claims a "volunteer force of over 5,000 dedicated and skilled amateur radio operators" that keep Army MARS ready to handle vital emergency communications."

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MARS member files Freedom of Information request

One Army MARS member took issue with the publicized emergency communications readiness and reported activity of the MARS program and filed a *Freedom of Information Act (FOIA)* request for a copy of a recent investigation into Army MARS by the Department of the Army's Inspector General (DAIG). The multi-page released excerpt from the audit report was very interesting to say the least ...and extremely critical of MARS value as an emergency communications medium in times of crisis.

The DAIG investigation began in the Spring of 2001 but its findings were not made public until June 2002. It has been reported that the full version of the actual audit report was many times the 41-pages that were released under the FOIA. Much of the full report could not be released due to Privacy Act and Law Enforcement concerns.

MARS support to state and local agencies

According to the May 22, 2002 investigative account, the MARS mission is somewhat different from that stated on their Home Page. The IG said (and we quote) "The focus of this mission is federal support and not support to state and local agencies. There are other organizations already in place to support state and local agencies (Radio Amateur Civil Emergency Service, RACES, American Radio Relay League ARRL, etc.) Without the authority of the Stafford Act, direct support of state and local agencies by agencies of the federal government is prohibited."

"All Federal Emergency Support to individual states starts with the Stafford Act." Under the *Stafford Disaster Assistance and Emergency Relief Act*, the Director of the *Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA)* has primary responsibility for the Federal Response Plan (FRP.)

"Without a Presidential declaration of an emergency, MARS has no authority to provide support at the local and state level." The Governor of the state involved must request the declaration of emergency. There are about 50 Presidentially Declared Disasters a year ...460 over the past ten years, the report said.

MARS fails to plan for disaster communications

According to the audit, MARS stations "participate in periodic exercises to maintain operator proficiency...." A DOD directive states that MARS "provides direct support" to the government in the event of a national disaster. But apparently they are doing a very poor job of it.

The Army Inspector General found that "MARS does not plan or train for this contingency mission nor does NMCS (the National Military Command System) include MARS in its planning, training, or exercise plan."

Included in the findings, is information confirming that Army MARS planning and exercise typically operates in a 'closed loop system' that results in MARS participants

talking to each other rather than providing point-to-point connectivity for supported customers. "These issues all point to a lack of appropriate planning and performance in providing actual emergency communications support to other agencies, particularly first responders."

Also mentioned in the report is that Army MARS may be "...focused more on socializing between operators than mission accomplishments." Another MARS member told us that "The entire program lacks any significant value in its current configuration and direction..." and that its current "organizational structure accomplishes little beyond recreational pursuit."

The audit report concludes that MARS fails to support military wartime communications and recommends that MARS include training to support NMCS.

MARS fails to participate in NCS training, meetings

The National Communications System (NCS) was formed in 1962 after the Cuban missile crisis. The goal of NCS is to provide communications support to critical Government functions during emergencies. The system links the communications systems of some 22 Federal agencies and departments, focusing on interconnectivity and survivability ...especially during a disaster.

Its membership includes such high level agencies as the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA), Dept. of Defense, Dept. of State, Federal Communications Commission (FCC), Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), the National Telecommunications and Information Administration (NTIA) and several others.

The National Communications System has a program developed through its member organizations called the SHARED RESOURCES (SHARES) High Frequency (HF) Radio Program. The purpose of SHARES is to provide a single, interagency emergency message handling system by bringing together existing HF radio resources of Federal, state and industry organizations when normal communications are destroyed or unavailable for the transmission of national security and emergency preparedness information.

The DAIG audit said that "MARS is also a member of the NCS SHARES HF Interoperability Working Group which assists, helps identify, records, and tracks issues affecting HF interoperability in the Federal government." But the Inspector General found that "There is no indication that MARS has participated in the planning, training, or participated in actual incidents with [NCS emergency management systems] or has actually attended or participated in any of the [Working Group] sessions." The DAIG said that MARS should assign someone to represent the program and participate as an active member.

MARS fails miserably on September 11

Another issue that the DAIG investigated is the accusation that MARS fails to support military, civil and/or disaster officials during declared emergencies with needed radio communications. Specifically mentioned is

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the terrorist attack of September 11, 2001 when the city of New York experienced a massive communications failure.

"This would have been an excellent opportunity for MARS to utilize its VHF capabilities and then to use HF links to pass real world traffic from the EOC [Emergency Operations Center] in New York to decision makers in Washington, D.C.," the audit report reads.

"With critical communications outages in New York and Washington, MARS links would have been invaluable for coordinating emergency responses and relief activities. Both the cell phone network and the regular phone system was down as was much of the power around the disaster site."

"MARS has the capability of establishing communications in this type of environment, but without planning and training, this capability cannot be realized. Simply stated, no one knew that MARS was there."

The Inspector General concluded that Army MARS is not prepared to execute its primary mission of providing emergency communications support. "In every presidentially declared emergency where Army MARS claimed participation, the same pattern was demonstrated."

"The potential for Army MARS to provide support in the aftermath of 11 September 2001 was phenomenal. Phone links from New York to Washington alone would have relayed critical information to the decision makers and would have helped make up for the loss of key communication links lost in the disaster. The MARS VHF capabilities could have assisted in clarifying the federal emergency response. Computer centers could have been linked via MARS HF links; and phone patches could have placed key individuals in contact with their organizations."

Although Army MARS established a radio net and remained on the air for several days the DAIG found that MARS were not prepared to handle needed communications and did very little in the way of emergency assistance "...except conduct radio checks." The audit report said MARS needed to implement a training program, participate with FEMA and NCS as a full participant and develop a program to inform the military and Federal emergency operations organizations of its capabilities.

MARS fails to provide timely communications

Historically, the most visible feature of Army MARS has traditionally been morale and welfare communications. The DAIG report mentions 'MARSgrams,' radioed morale-boosting messages that were handled for military service personnel during the Korean, Vietnam and Desert Storm conflicts.

"According to numbers provided by the Chief, Army MARS, 180,000 MARSgrams and 60,000 radiophone patches were made for service members deployed during Desert Shield/Storm alone." The DAIG agreed that evidence amply demonstrates that MARS continues to have the capability to make phone patches and send MARSgrams supporting soldiers around the world.

It said one of the problems identified was that MARSgrams were not handled in a timely manner. "Procedures need to be established which will eliminate MARSgrams remaining in collection boxes for weeks on end."

The DAIG recommended that procedures be developed to reduce time required to process MARSgrams and to expand phone patch capabilities for use in supporting other Federal agencies. A public relations program should be established since "Many soldiers simply do not know about MARSgrams or phone patches."

MARS membership decreases, equipment poor

The Inspector General agreed with the accusation that Army MARS does not furnish adequate training in military communications equipment, techniques and procedures. It said that although it attempts to increase MARS participants "...the Army MARS program has lost 55% of its membership in the last 20 months. ...to less than 2,200 volunteer members." The number of active duty military personnel and paid staff associated with the Army MARS program is minimal. The Chief, Army MARS is a GS civilian position.

"The fact that recruitment is an extremely high priority, especially with the current budget constraints, is not the question. The actual issue is the question of whether Army MARS furnishes appropriate training...." MARS is not able to train in military communications equipment which must be remedied.

"Even though the Army does allow Army MARS members to participate in an equipment 'reutilization' program, radio equipment in this program is notoriously out of date and has very limited use to the individual members."

Currently funding for Army MARS does not include acquisition of new equipment or even maintenance of the older equipment.

MARS is "misleading"

According to the MARS website, "MARS has a long and proud history of providing world-wide auxiliary emergency communications during times of need. Our volunteer force of over 5,000 dedicated and skilled amateur radio operators is the back bone of our program. The benefit of MARS membership is enjoying an amateur radio hobby through the ever-expanding horizon of MARS. Our affiliate members' continued unselfish support of our mission keeps Army MARS Proud, Professional, and Ready."

The Army's Inspector General took issue with MARS publicized outward appearance versus reality and asserted that "The presentation of information to the chain-of-command, to the Army MARS membership, and to the public by the Army MARS staff was misleading and deceptive." It recommended that the MARS Web Page be reviewed and that the membership numbers be revised to reflect current affiliate numbers. Even some of

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the 2,200 members may no longer be active.

The report also said that Major Disaster Support (Success Stories) should be deleted since "MARS was not mentioned as a participant by FEMA during any presidentially declared emergency during the past ten years," nor have they participated in any development or planning sessions of FEMA. "There is not a single mention of Army MARS or Army MARS support by either FEMA or NCS during any of the 460 Presidentialy Declared Major Disasters," the DAIG remarked.

In short, the Army Inspector General's investigative audit found very little that Army MARS is doing ...or doing right, to support the emergency or disaster communications needs of the U.S. Federal or civil government.

CHIEF, ARMY MARS REGARDING INVESTIGATION

It is my understanding that the DAIG investigation was undertaken as a result of a request by Congress, specifically Rep. Jim Ryun's (R-KS) and Senator Kay Bailey Hutchison (R-TX).

The Chief of Army MARS is Bob Sutton, N7UZY (Technician Class) of Sierra Vista, Arizona. I telephoned him and read him the prior story, a version of which will also run in the October issue of *Monitoring Times* magazine. In the interest of balance, I thought it was only fair to let him know that I had a copy of the DAIG Investigative Report and give him an opportunity to publicly respond to its allegations.

Bob Sutton acknowledged that he also had seen the audit report but that he could not respond to it. He said Army policy dictated that all public statements had to be funneled through the Fort Huachuca Public Affairs Office.

I received a telephone call the following day from a Carol Conner, a very pleasant lady who said she was the "U.S. Army Public Affairs Officer." She asked me to e-mail her a copy of the story which I did. She confirmed receipt and said she would get back to me. On Friday, August 23rd, she e-mailed me the following response:

US ARMY SIGNAL COMMAND'S RESPONSE

"The Department of the Army Inspector General (DAIG) investigative report on the Army Military Affiliate Radio System (MARS) raises valid points. US Army Signal Command (USASC) is in the process of reviewing the findings and implementing changes.

Like many other military programs, Army MARS is working with constrained resources after years of budget cuts, and must compete with other organizations to fund sometimes-unforeseen expenditures. That said, US Army Signal Command remains committed to the MARS mission.

The Army MARS budget has increased by a total of \$60,000 over the last four fiscal years and the ASC command has initiated funding requests to upgrade equipment located in overseas gateway stations. A contract was also let in September 1999 and implemented in Octo-

ber 1999 that hired full-time operators at both the Eastern and Western Gateways, which are located at Fort Huachuca, Ariz., and Fort Detrick, Md., making them 24-hour operations. Phase two of the contract, implemented in October 2000, added two additional positions (Eastern and Western area coordinators).

As a result of the DAIG investigative findings, Army Signal Command has taken actions to update Army MARS procedural manuals. A new Army MARS Net Plan was published in August 2001 and revised in July 2002. A revised National Emergency Operations plan was published in April 2002. Several new training guides have also been updated. The Net Control Station Guide was published in October 2001. The Essential Elements of Information Reporting Guide was published in March 2002 and a totally new Basic Training Manual was released in July 2002.

The DAIG report cited discrepancies on our website. The Army MARS website is currently under review, changes have been made and the site will be updated on a regular basis.

Army Signal Command is also dedicated to getting out the word about the great things Army MARS volunteers are doing. As we transition to US Army Network Enterprise Technology Command, we will be establishing a presence in the National Capital Region and will have a designated representative attending the Shared Resources High Frequency Radio Program meetings as well as other events that require an Army MARS voice.

The USASC command believes Army MARS is a viable program. We remain committed to its mission and the thousands of volunteers who support it. US Army Signal Command will become US Army Network Enterprise Technology Command/9th Army Signal Command, effective October 1, 2002."

AMATEUR RADIO STATION CALL SIGNS

...sequentially issued as of the first of September 1, 2002:

District	Extra	Advanced	Tech./General/Novice
0	AB0WR	KI0SK	→ KC0NZE
1	AB1BL	KE1ME	→ KB1IRV
2	AB2PO	KG2RR	→ KC2KDS
3	AA3ZZ	KF3ED	→ KB3IMX
4	AG4VQ	KV4GL	→ KG4UUZ
5	AD5LT	KM5XR	→ KD5TRF
6	AE6IF	KR6FD	→ KG6MYB
7	AC7VT	KK7XI	→ KD7SMF
8	AB8PR	KI8KD	→ KC8UQW
9	AB9GN	KG9QU	→ KC9CHW
Hawaii	→	AH6RO	NH7OH WH6DGT
Alaska	→	AL7RR	KL1JC WL7CVQ
Virgin Isl.	→	KP2CS	NP2LY WP2AIP
Puerto Rico	WP3T	KP3BN	WP3SW WP4NOZ

[Source: FCC Amateur Service Database, Washington, DC]